A TALEX MEDIA REPORT

THE 2027 BRANDED SERIES REPORT

What audiences ask brands for, what they trust, and five brand series to watch.

DECEMBER 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Social media users are asking brands for series. When Sprout Social asked what brands should prioritize in 2026, 57%[1] said original content series, nearly tied with the top answer.

Three other numbers point the same way: about two-thirds of US Google searches produce no click[2], Meta's average price per ad has been higher than a year earlier in every quarter since the start of 2025[3], and in a US survey most people who view online content trust AI-generated content less than human-made content[4]. Four findings follow, with five brand series to watch.

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01

THE NUMBERS

Six figures behind the findings.

57%

of social media users say brands should prioritize original series.[1]

68%

of US Google searches in the first four months of 2026 produced no click.[2]

27%

fewer impressions when a personal LinkedIn post carries a link.[5]

14%

rise in Meta's average price per ad, year over year.[3]

69%

of US online content viewers trust AI-generated content less than human-made.[4]

67%

of the Volvo Trucks channel's YouTube views come from one series.[6]

FINDING 01

01

Social media users are asking brands for series

Sprout Social asked social media users what brands should prioritize in 2026. Original content series came in at 57%[1], nearly tied with the top answer, interacting with audiences.

Aéropostale's The Intern Diaries stars creator Déjà Clark, and its second season has six episodes of about three to four minutes each. Marisa Thalberg of Catalyst Brands told Digiday that the show overall cost "really low six figures"[7].

Bob's Discount Furniture cast six real couples as contestants in Till Decor Do Us Part, hosted by comedian Gabby Bryan. The first season drove $9 million in attributed sales[8], and a second season followed in fall 2026.



THE INTERN DIARIES · AÉROPOSTALE · SEASON 2, EPISODE 1 · 3:49

"Two times the engagement" on Instagram against the brand's regular content, Thalberg told Digiday.[7]



TILL DECOR DO US PART · BOB'S DISCOUNT FURNITURE · SEASON 1, EPISODE 2 · 1:40

$9 million in attributed sales from the first season.[8]

IN PRACTICE

Plan a first season as a handful of short episodes built around one person your audience would choose to watch.

FINDING 02

02

The click is harder to get, and it costs more

In the first four months of 2026, 68%[2] of US Google searches ended without a click, up from 60% in 2024, SparkToro found. When Google showed an AI summary, Pew Research found, people clicked a traditional result on 8% of visits, against 15% without one[9].

LinkedIn shows a similar pattern. Personal-profile posts with a link got 27% fewer impressions and 20% fewer interactions than posts without one[5]. Paid reach costs more too. Meta's average price per ad rose 14%[3] year over year in the third quarter of 2026, and the price has been higher than a year earlier in every quarter since the start of 2025.

An episode watched where the viewer found it needs no click. In Shopify's Make My Space Work, a designer rebuilds one small-business owner's workspace per episode, and the owners on camera are Shopify's customers.



MAKE MY SPACE WORK · SHOPIFY · 15:22
5.0 million views across the 27 videos on the series channel.[6]

IN PRACTICE

Make each episode complete on the platform where it is posted. Count how many people watched it before you count visits to your site.

FINDING 03

03

Viewers trust human-made content more than AI-generated content

In a YouGov survey of US adults, 69%[4] of people who view online content said they trust AI-generated content less than human-generated content. In the same survey, 61%[4] said they are unlikely to read or engage with content they think is AI-generated.

LinkedIn's chief product officer, Hari Srinivasan, wrote in August 2026 that members were seeing "40% less views on what we classify as AI slop"[10] than a few weeks earlier.

Every series embedded in this report puts real people on camera. YETI Presents is 90 documentaries, each about one person telling a story from their own life.



A THOUSAND CASTS, FROM YETI PRESENTS · YETI · 28:29
38.2 million views across the 90 films in the library.[6]

IN PRACTICE

Build each episode around a real person telling a story that is theirs.

FINDING 04

Posting less can still grow an audience

04

Inter Milan cut the content it posted by about a third[11] over the past year. Across the club's channels, followers rose about 20%, impressions 43% and video views 33%.

Frequency still counts for followers. In Buffer's data, accounts posting 10 or more times a week gained an average of 32 more followers a week than in weeks they didn't post[12]. Buffer's analysis also suggests that reach per post tends to fall as frequency rises[12].

A series can run on few episodes. Huckberry's DIRT has published 18 in four and a half years, about four a year, with a median length of 34 minutes.



NEW YORK CITY, FROM DIRT · HUCKBERRY · 24:37
24.1 million views across 18 episodes.[6]

IN PRACTICE

Choose a release pace your team can hold for a year.

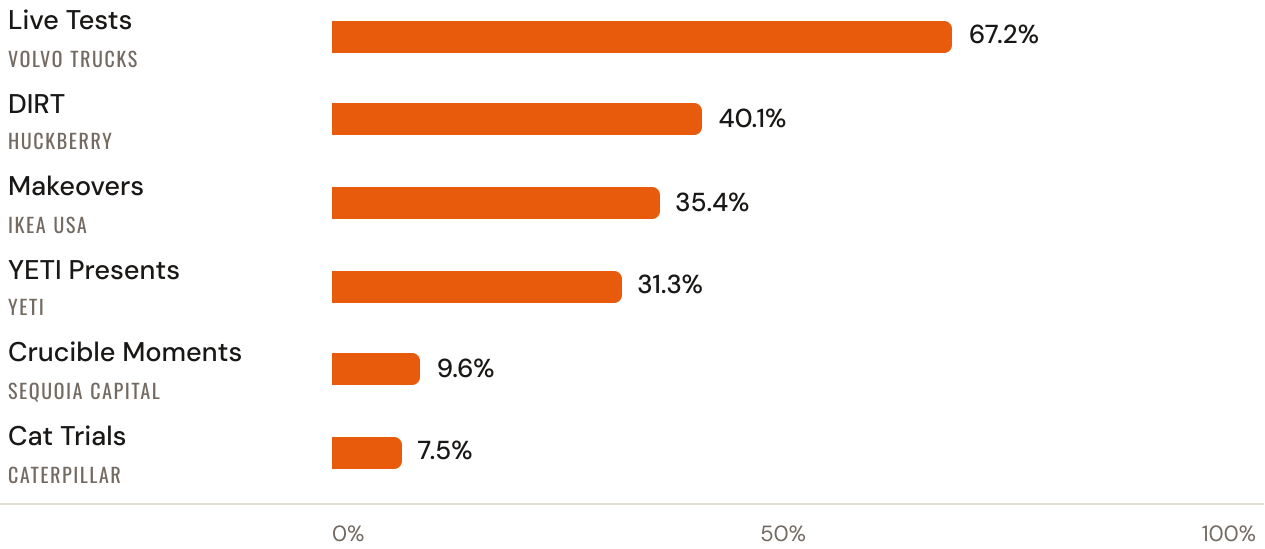
OUR OWN NUMBERS

What 19 brand series show on YouTube

Talex tracks 19 brand series on YouTube, chosen because they worked, so the figures show what success looks like and do not prove that series succeed. YouTube view counts can include paid views.

SHARE OF THE CHANNEL'S LIFETIME YOUTUBE VIEWS

Each series against all views on the channel that hosts it. Read 11 November 2026.[6]



One series can account for most of a channel's views.

The 33 Live Tests films make up 67.2%[6] of all views on the Volvo Trucks channel. DIRT is 40.1%[6] of Huckberry's and YETI Presents 31.3%[6] of YETI's. Cat Trials is 7.5%[6] of Caterpillar's product channel.

Five of the 19 span more than a decade.

The five series are Roadkill, Will It Blend?, Live Tests, Cat Trials and YETI Presents[6].

Companies that sell to businesses make series too.

Seven of the 19 do[6]. Sequoia Capital's Crucible Moments has 1.95 million views across 21 documentaries of about 42 minutes each at the median[6].

Most of the longer series run about 7 to 15 minutes an episode.

Of the 11 series with a median episode over five minutes, eight have a median between 6:55 and 14:49[6].

Most of the series keep the brand out of the episode title.

In 11 of the 19, no episode title contains the brand's name[6].

2027

PREDICTIONS

Tom's 2027 predictions go here once he records them.

SELF-CHECK

FIVE QUESTIONS BEFORE YOU MAKE IT

01 If you stripped your name and your product off this piece of content, would anyone still want to watch it?

02 Can you describe the format in one sentence, so a viewer of one episode knows what the next will be?

03 Is a real person on camera, telling a story that is theirs?

04 Does the piece hold a viewer on the platform where it is watched, without needing a click?

05 Could your team still be making it a year from now?

TALK IT THROUGH

If one of these series gave you an idea for your own, bring it to a call with our team.

BOOK A CALL WITH OUR TEAM

2X EMMY NOMINATED | 25 YEARS EXPERIENCE | 100+ HOURS DISTRIBUTED GLOBALLY

BBC · DISCOVERY · NBC UNIVERSAL

TALEXMEDIA.COM SOLUTIONS@TALEXMEDIA.COM

2027

Sources and notes

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Every series in this report was made by the company named with it. Talex did not make them.

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